

2026 BIG TEN CONFERENCE PRIMER

BIG TEN CONFERENCE

Conference outlook, tiers, projected order,
schedule inflection points and team directory.

WHAT DEFINES THE 2026 BIG TEN?

Three national-title-caliber teams.

A deep second tier with very different paths.

Schedule difficulty can reorder the middle.

Independent publication. Not affiliated with or endorsed by the Big Ten Conference.

BIG TEN AT A GLANCE

2026 CONFERENCE OVERVIEW

18 teams - 2026 preseason outlook

How to read the rankings: The **Primer power rating** estimates neutral-field team quality in points above or below an average FBS team. **Expected wins** is schedule-aware and reflects the full 12-game path. Those are intentionally different measures: a team can be stronger than another team while still projecting for fewer wins.

1. 60-Second Big Ten Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good is the Big Ten?	The strongest top end in the project, with three genuine national-title teams and another four teams carrying top-20 underlying quality. Ohio State, Oregon and Indiana begin in a tier that can win the whole sport; USC, Michigan, Penn State and Washington form a second wave capable of changing the playoff race.
Title favorite	Ohio State, narrowly. The Buckeyes lead the entire project at +32.5 in Primer power, but Oregon sits close behind at +29.0 and defending national champion Indiana remains elite at +26.0 .
Most important challenger distinction	Oregon has the cleanest combination of returning QB certainty and elite two-way talent; Indiana has the strongest recent proof but the largest replacement burden. Both are championship teams, just with different sources of risk.
Best schedule-path team	Penn State. The Nittany Lions are only sixth in Big Ten underlying power at +16.0 but fourth in expected wins at 9.0 , helped by SP+ SOS No. 59 and unusual staff/QB familiarity in the Matt Campbell-Rocco Becht transition.
Best better-than-record profiles	Michigan and USC. Both carry top-15-ish neutral-field quality, but Michigan faces SP+ SOS No. 5 and USC No. 11. An 8-4 or even 7-5 record would not necessarily mean either is merely an 8-4 or 7-5 caliber team.
Biggest league-wide storyline	The Big Ten is simultaneously elite at the top and unstable in the middle. New staffs, QB changes and OL reconstruction appear throughout the second and third tiers, while schedule sequencing can move similarly rated teams several standings places apart.

Conference identity: The Big Ten enters 2026 with the sport's clearest three-team championship cluster. Ohio State has the strongest overall roster baseline, Oregon brings elite QB continuity and defensive-front stability, and Indiana must prove that Curt Cignetti's system can absorb another enormous NFL exodus without losing title-level efficiency. Behind them, the conference becomes much harder to sort. USC, Michigan and Washington look stronger than their projected records, Penn State may win more games than its raw roster ranking suggests, and Iowa remains a high-floor ranked-caliber team despite a major QB/OL transition.

Bottom line: The Big Ten title race starts with three national-title teams, but the standings behind them will be heavily shaped by schedule rather than clean talent order. Reading the league correctly requires separating championship quality, playoff path and simple win total.

Five things to remember

- 1 Ohio State, Oregon and Indiana are the championship tier.** All three can finish with two regular-season losses and still be legitimate national-title teams because none has a soft schedule or a roster free of replacement risk.
- 2 Penn State is the clearest record-vs-power outlier.** The Nittany Lions project for nine wins despite ranking behind USC, Michigan and Washington in neutral-field quality because the schedule and imported staff/QB ecosystem create a cleaner path.
- 3 Michigan and USC are better than their likely records.** Both own top-20 power profiles and top-11 schedules, so a merely good win total can hide genuine playoff-level weekly quality.
- 4 Quarterback certainty separates the top from much of the middle.** Julian Sayin and Dante Moore are elite returning anchors, while Indiana, Penn State, Michigan, Washington and USC at least enter with defined QB1s. Iowa and several lower-half teams carry much wider outcome bands.

5 **The league's lower half is not uniformly weak.** Minnesota, Maryland, UCLA, Northwestern, Wisconsin and Rutgers all have plausible bowl paths, but each needs one high-leverage unit to stabilize before the schedule exposes it.

2. Conference Power Structure

Tier	Teams	Read
Championship Tier	Ohio State, Oregon, Indiana	Ohio State is the strongest neutral-field team in the project, Oregon is only a small step behind with elite QB/front continuity, and Indiana remains a top-five-caliber team despite replacing the No. 1 NFL pick and a large championship core.
High-End Contenders	USC, Michigan, Penn State, Washington	USC and Michigan are top-20 teams facing punishing schedules; Penn State has the easiest path but more transition risk; Washington has the settled QB and two-way baseline to outperform its roster volatility.
Ranked-Caliber Middle	Iowa, Illinois, Nebraska	Iowa's defense preserves a high floor, Illinois has a stable QB/leadership spine, and Nebraska's metrics are stronger than its expected record even though all three carry meaningful transition questions.
Bowl-Line Middle	Minnesota, UCLA, Maryland, Northwestern, Wisconsin	Each has a credible six-win case, but none has enough certainty across QB, OL and defense to separate cleanly from the pack.
Bottom of the Table	Rutgers, Michigan State, Purdue	Rutgers has proven offensive star power, Michigan State has a functional QB/RB structure, and Purdue should improve, but all three remain low-continuity teams with difficult schedules and multiple unsettled units.

The defining feature is the gap between the first three and everyone else. **Ohio State, Oregon and Indiana all carry a Primer power rating of +26.0 or better.** USC is next at +17.5. That is a real tier break, not a branding choice. The second important feature is the shape of the middle: Michigan, Penn State, Washington and Iowa are separated by only 2.5 power points, but their expected wins range from 7.4 to 9.0 because the schedules are so different.

3. Projected Conference Order

This is a schedule-aware projected order, anchored by expected overall wins and then adjusted editorially for team quality and uncertainty. It is not the underlying Big Ten power ranking.

Rank	Team	Expected season	Power	One-line thesis
1	Ohio State	10.2 wins - 10-2	+32.5	The country's strongest underlying team, with elite QB/WR/OL talent and enough defensive replacement quality to survive a top-three schedule.
2	Oregon	10.2 - 10-2	+29.0	Dante Moore and an elite defensive front preserve championship quality while the rebuilt OL and specialist operation create the main uncertainty.
3	Indiana	10.0 - 10-2	+26.0	The defending champion still has title-level coaching, OL and defensive structure, but Josh Hoover and a large replacement class must reproduce historic efficiency.
4	Penn State	9.0 - 9-3	+16.0	Matt Campbell, Rocco Becht and a favorable path give Penn State the conference's clearest chance for the record to outrun raw roster ranking.
5	Iowa	8.0 - 8-4	+14.5	The Hawkeyes remain ranked-caliber because the defense sets a high floor, but the QB competition and three drafted OL departures widen the range.
6	USC	7.8 - 8-4	+17.5	A playoff-quality offense and top-15 power profile face a top-11 schedule plus new defensive-coordinator and OL-transition risk.
7	Washington	7.8 - 8-4	+16.0	Demond Williams Jr. gives the Huskies a high offensive floor, but premium NFL losses and a difficult November limit record certainty.
8	Michigan	7.4 - 7-5	+17.0	Top-15 underlying talent can coexist with seven wins because a new staff, rebuilt front seven and SP+ SOS No. 5 create constant stress.
9	Illinois	7.1 - 7-5	+10.5	A stable veteran QB/leadership core keeps Illinois in the top-30 range, but both sides must absorb major turnover against a top-25 schedule.

Rank	Team	Expected season	Power	One-line thesis
10	Nebraska	6.2 - 6-6	+9.5	The metrics support an eight-win ceiling, but QB/RB change and SP+ SOS No. 10 make a modest record more likely than the underlying quality suggests.
11	Minnesota	6.1 - 6-6	+6.0	QB continuity and a useful defensive front create a bowl floor, while explosive offense and defensive replacement remain the ceiling questions.
12	Maryland	6.0 - 6-6	+5.0	Malik Washington gives Maryland more stability than a typical rebound team, but run-game inefficiency and secondary turnover keep the projection near the bowl line.
13	UCLA	5.9 - 6-6	+5.5	Nico Iamaleava and the new staff create rebound upside, but transfer-heavy trench and defensive reconstruction make the translation highly uncertain.
14	Wisconsin	5.7 - 6-6	+4.0	The defense can support a bowl bid, but the offense is being rebuilt around a Power 4 newcomer at QB and an unsettled OL.
15	Rutgers	5.4 - 5-7	+2.5	Antwan Raymond and KJ Duff give the offense real star power, but a new QB, rebuilt OL and near-total secondary reset dominate the downside.
16	Northwestern	5.3 - 5-7	+5.0	The Wildcats are better than 16th on a neutral field, but SP+ SOS No. 6 and a new QB/rebuilt OL squeeze a defense-first bowl profile.
17	Michigan State	4.6 - 5-7	+2.0	A clearer QB/RB structure raises the floor, but low continuity and a difficult late schedule make a full rebound too aggressive.
18	Purdue	3.4 - 3-9	-2.0	Ryan Browne gives the rebuild a stable center, but the amount of OL/skill/defensive turnover and a top-20 schedule keep Purdue at the bottom.

The biggest standings distortion is **Penn State versus Michigan/USC/Washington**. Penn State ranks sixth in underlying Big Ten power but fourth in expected wins. Michigan ranks fifth in power but eighth in expected wins; USC is fourth in power but sixth in expected wins. **Northwestern** is another smaller version of the same phenomenon: its +5.0 rating is tied for 13th in the league, but the No. 6 national SOS pushes the Wildcats to 16th in projected order.

4. The Title Race

The Big Ten has three teams that can win the national championship without requiring a surprise leap. They arrive there from different starting points.

Ohio State - the strongest baseline in the sport

Ohio State begins at **+32.5**, No. 1 in Big Ten and national Primer power. Julian Sayin returns after leading an elite passing offense, Jeremiah Smith remains the conference's defining skill matchup, and the interior offensive line gives the Buckeyes enough stability to survive a new play-caller. The question is not offensive ceiling. It is whether a defense returning only 49% of production can stay close enough to its extraordinary 2025 standard after multiple first-round departures.

The schedule prevents autopilot. Ohio State travels to Texas before league play, then later faces Indiana, USC and Nebraska on the road with Oregon and Michigan at home. A 10-2 regular season would not be evidence that the roster missed expectations. It would still be fully compatible with the best team in the country surviving one of the nation's hardest paths.

Oregon - the cleanest returning championship spine

Oregon's **+29.0** rating reflects unusual certainty at the two places most likely to survive turnover: quarterback and defensive front. Dante Moore is a settled elite QB1, while A'Mauri Washington and a veteran front preserve the defense's safest strength. The uncertainty is concentrated rather than diffuse. Multiple NFL departures leave the offensive line rebuilding around center Iapani Laloulou, and the kicking/punting/long-snapping operation resets at once.

Dave Luli's late-camp trajectory improved toward opener availability, which helps the OL outlook without changing the broader thesis. If Oregon's best five settles quickly, there is no meaningful ceiling gap between the Ducks and Ohio State. The schedule's defining feature is the November sequence: at Ohio State, Michigan, at Michigan State and Washington.

Indiana - the defending champion's replacement test

Indiana's 16-0 peak was real, and so is the 2026 replacement burden. Josh Hoover steps into the quarterback job after Fernando Mendoza went No. 1 overall in the NFL draft, while the offense also replaces drafted skill production and the defense replaces major pieces at edge and in the secondary. That would normally pull a team much farther down the board.

The reason it does not is the infrastructure. Curt Cignetti, Mike Shanahan and Bryant Haines preserve the system; Carter Smith and the OL core give Hoover protection; and the defense still has high-end front-seven anchors. Indiana remains **+26.0** because the coaching and line structure reduce how much the new pieces have to solve independently. Ohio State at home and Michigan on the road in consecutive October weeks will tell us whether the replacement class is merely good or championship-good.

Penn State - the schedule-path challenger

Penn State is not in the same neutral-field tier at **+16.0**, but the path deserves separate attention. Matt Campbell arrives with Rocco Becht and a large amount of system familiarity, while SP+ SOS No. 59 is dramatically softer than the schedules assigned to Ohio State, Michigan or USC. The Nittany Lions can finish above stronger teams in the standings without that outcome being contradictory.

That makes Penn State the conference's most interesting championship-game path team. The roster still depends heavily on newcomers, especially across the OL and defensive front, but a 9-3 baseline plus home games against USC and much of the middle creates room for a transition season to produce a top-four conference record.

The disruption group: USC, Michigan and Washington are all strong enough to knock a title-tier team out of Indianapolis. USC has the best offense of the three, Michigan the strongest raw top-15 roster case despite its schedule, and Washington the most stable quarterback situation. None has the clean enough path to enter the title tier, but all three can decide who wins it.

5. Teams Most Likely to Be Better Than Their Record

Michigan - top-15 quality, top-five schedule

Michigan is the clearest Big Ten example of why record and quality must be separated. The Wolverines are **+17.0**, fifth in conference power, but only **7.4 expected wins** because SP+ rates the schedule No. 5 nationally. Bryce Underwood returns as a settled QB1 and captain, the OL has real anchors, and the roster remains talented enough to beat anyone outside the top three.

The schedule repeatedly removes margin: Oklahoma in nonconference play, then Penn State, Indiana, Oregon and Ohio State in league play. A 7-5 finish would look ordinary in a standings table while remaining compatible with a genuine top-20 team navigating one of the sport's hardest slates under a new staff.

USC - playoff offense, playoff schedule

USC is slightly stronger at **+17.5** and projects for **7.8 wins** against SP+ SOS No. 11. Jayden Maiava gives Lincoln Riley high-end QB continuity, and the offense has enough proven production to function at playoff level. The uncertainty sits on defense and in protection, where a coordinator change, defensive replacement and Kilian O'Connor's season-ending loss all matter.

The Trojans host Oregon and Ohio State, visit Penn State and Indiana, and also play Washington. That is enough elite-opponent density that 8-4 can describe an excellent team more accurately than an inconsistent one.

Washington - a top-20 team with a punishing finish

Washington's **+16.0** rating and **7.8 expected wins** reflect both the upside of Demond Williams Jr. and the cost of replacing premium NFL talent. The defense retains enough of its spine to keep the floor high, but the OL and overall depth are less settled than the headline ranking suggests.

The Huskies' late schedule is the reason to remember them as a quality-over-record team: Nebraska on the road, Penn State at home, Michigan State on the road, Indiana at home and Oregon on the road close the season. If Washington finishes 8-4 while remaining dangerous against playoff teams, the record should not be read as evidence that the top-20 evaluation was wrong.

Nebraska - improvement can hide inside 6-6

Nebraska is **+9.5**, a top-35-ish underlying profile, yet projects for only **6.2 wins** against SP+ SOS No. 10. Anthony Colandrea replaces Dylan Raiola, the RB rotation changes and the defensive structure resets under Rob Aurich, so there is real transition. There is also more quality than the expected record implies.

The schedule gets materially harder after the opening phase, including Indiana, Oregon, Washington, Illinois and Ohio State. A six- or seven-win season could still represent real program improvement if the Cornhuskers are more efficient and competitive against that stretch.

6. Teams Whose Record May Run Ahead of Their Power

Penn State - the clearest case

Penn State's **9.0 expected wins** stand out next to a **+16.0** power rating. That is still a strong top-20 team, but USC, Michigan and Washington all rate at least as well or better on a neutral field. The combination of SP+ SOS No. 59, a stable imported QB/system connection and a schedule without Ohio State, Oregon or Indiana creates a path for the standings to flatter the roster ranking slightly.

That is not a bearish Penn State argument. It is a calibration rule: if the Nittany Lions reach 10 wins, the record alone should not automatically move them into the Ohio State/Oregon/Indiana talent tier.

Iowa - the high-floor version

Iowa is **+14.5** with **8.0 expected wins**, a relatively modest gap but still an important one. The defensive identity remains trustworthy enough to survive lower offensive output, and the schedule avoids Oregon, Indiana and USC. At the same time, the Hawkeyes are replacing their starting quarterback and three NFL-drafted offensive linemen, so an 8-4 record could reflect program floor and schedule management more than a clean top-15 roster.

Wisconsin - bowl record can outpace roster certainty

Wisconsin sits at **+4.0** but projects for **5.7 wins**, putting a bowl season squarely in range. The defense is the stabilizer; the offense is not yet that trustworthy. Colton Joseph is new to Power 4 play, the OL is rebuilt and health-dependent, and the skill structure is still taking shape. Six wins would be meaningful progress without proving that Wisconsin has returned to upper-tier Big Ten quality.

7. The Bottom of the Table

The lower half is not one category. Some teams have stable identities but limited ceilings; others are rebuilding around a new coach or quarterback; a few are one successful unit translation away from a bowl. These are the teams most likely to disappear from title-focused discussion even though they will decide much of the league's middle.

Minnesota - continuity searching for explosiveness

Minnesota is the most stable team in this section. Drake Lindsey returns at quarterback, the coaching structure is intact and the OL has useful anchors. The problem is that the 2025 offense was among the least explosive in the country, so continuity only matters if it produces a different downfield and rushing profile. Anthony Smith gives the defensive front a genuine star, but multiple veteran departures mean the defense cannot be asked to carry the entire improvement case.

A six-win baseline is reasonable. The path to eight is not complicated: the offense has to become more dangerous without losing the possession-and-field-position identity that keeps Minnesota competitive.

Maryland - more stable than the record suggests

Maryland enters after a four-win season but is not a typical bottom-tier rebuild. Malik Washington returns after a productive true-freshman season, and the roster retains enough offensive and front-seven structure to make bowl eligibility realistic. The biggest limitation is efficiency: the run game must become more reliable and the defense has to replace important secondary production while playing without a key front piece.

The Terrapins' schedule is difficult rather than catastrophic, which makes six wins a fair midpoint. This is a team that can look much more functional without producing a dramatic standings leap.

UCLA - the translation test

UCLA's **+5.5** rating says the talent is good enough for a bowl. The confidence is lower because so much of the projection depends on translation. Nico Iamaleava is an established QB1 but is learning a new offense, Bob Chesney is installing a new program structure, and the OL/defense rely heavily on imported pieces.

The question is not whether the staff upgrade makes sense long term. It is whether system familiarity and transfer talent can hold up immediately against Big Ten line play. If the OL stabilizes, UCLA can jump several places. If it does not, the new structure may need a year before the record follows.

Northwestern - defense versus schedule

Northwestern is tied with Maryland at **+5.0** in power but projects lower because SP+ SOS No. 6 is one of the nation's hardest schedules. The defense should remain the stronger side; the offense has to prove that Aidan Chiles is a meaningful QB upgrade while replacing two drafted offensive linemen.

That creates a narrow bowl path. Northwestern does not need an elite offense, but it does need enough efficiency and explosiveness that the defense is not forced to play perfectly against Ohio State, Penn State and the rest of a difficult league slate.

Rutgers - proven stars around a major reset

Rutgers may have the most obvious individual offensive production in the bottom group. RB Antwan Raymond and WR KJ Duff are proven high-volume players, giving Dylan Loneragan useful answers as he takes over QB1. The problem is everything around that core: the OL loses major experience, the defense was poor by nearly every efficiency measure in 2025, and the secondary is almost completely rebuilt.

New DC Travis Johansen does not need to create an elite defense for Rutgers to reach a bowl. He needs the imported front to create enough disruption that the new secondary is not exposed on every successful down. Five to six wins is a sensible range because the offense can be good while the defense remains volatile.

Michigan State - a clearer offensive center, still too much churn

Michigan State has a more coherent starting point than the 2025 record might imply. Alessio Milivojevic owns the quarterback job, Cam Edwards provides proven lead-back production, and Jordan Hall gives the defense a second-level anchor. The issue is shared continuity across WR, OL, the defensive front, secondary and specialists.

The late schedule is particularly unforgiving: after the bye, Michigan State goes to Michigan, hosts Washington and then hosts Oregon. A five-win season can still contain meaningful progress if the QB/RB structure works and the rebuilt defense becomes more disruptive.

Purdue - improvement without a bowl expectation

Purdue should be better than 2-10 because Ryan Browne and Josh Henson give the offense continuity at the two most important operational roles. That is a real floor-raising asset. The rest of the roster is still being rebuilt around them: five transfer OL candidates are competing to form a new best five, the top three 2025 receiving-yard producers are gone, and the defense replaces major tackle and pass-rush production.

The **-2.0** power rating and SP+ SOS No. 18 make three to four wins a more responsible baseline than a bowl call. The useful success marker is whether Browne turns continuity into a functional offense and the transfer-heavy lines become stable enough that Purdue is no longer structurally overmatched.

8. Quarterback Landscape

The Big Ten quarterback picture is much stronger at the top than it is uniform across the league.

QB tier	Teams	Read
Elite returning anchors	Ohio State, Oregon	Julian Sayin and Dante Moore return after elite 2025 seasons and give the two highest-rated teams unusually stable championship foundations.
Established high-upside QB1s	USC, Michigan, Washington	Jayden Maiava, Bryce Underwood and Demond Williams Jr. all bring meaningful starting proof and can carry top-20 offenses if protection holds.
Defined starters with transition attached	Indiana, Penn State, Illinois, Nebraska, Minnesota, Maryland	Josh Hoover, Rocco Becht, Katin Houser, Anthony Colandrea, Drake Lindsey and Malik Washington are known QB1s, but each team is pairing that certainty with a new system, role expansion or major surrounding turnover.
Bowl-tier starters with wider ranges	UCLA, Northwestern, Wisconsin, Rutgers, Michigan State, Purdue	Nico Iamaleava, Aidan Chiles, Colton Joseph, Dylan Lonergan, Alessio Milivojevic and Ryan Browne all have plausible floor-raising cases, but none is surrounded by enough certainty to remove the volatility.
Open competition	Iowa	Hank Brown and Jeremy Hecklinski remain in competition, making QB the clearest unresolved high-leverage role on an otherwise ranked-caliber team.

Two league-wide points matter. First, **the title tier does not depend on quarterback projection alone**. Ohio State and Oregon return elite starters, while Indiana can protect Hoover with one of the league's best OL/coaching structures. Second, the middle is full of teams where the quarterback may be good enough but the line or supporting cast is not settled. That is why USC, Washington, Nebraska, UCLA, Rutgers and Michigan State carry wider ranges than the QB name alone would suggest.

9. Line-of-Scrimmage / Roster Continuity Themes

The Big Ten title race is unusually sensitive to offensive-line continuity because several elite teams are replacing NFL volume elsewhere. A stable OL can keep a roster transition from becoming a full-team transition.

Team	OL	DL/Edge	Why it matters
Ohio State	A-, stable	A-, down	The interior OL is a championship anchor; the defensive front has enough talent to reload but must replace major professional production.
Oregon	B+, down	A, stable	The veteran defensive front is the safest unit on the roster, while the OL's unsettled configuration is the clearest obstacle to an otherwise elite profile.
Indiana	A-, stable	B+, down	The OL can insulate Josh Hoover and preserve offensive identity; Tyrique Tucker anchors a defense replacing major edge/secondary production.
USC	B+, volatile	B, changing	A veteran offense loses an important center piece to injury while the defense needs transfer/new-coordinator cohesion.
Michigan	B+, mixed	B+, down	Useful OL anchors and front talent remain, but new combinations and veteran defensive departures meet a top-five schedule.
Penn State	B-, down	B, down	Both lines rely heavily on newcomers, making the favorable schedule especially important while Campbell's system settles.
Iowa	B-, down	B-, down	Replacing three drafted OL starters plus front-seven production creates more volatility than the program's defensive reputation suggests.
Minnesota	B, stable	B+, down	The OL gives the offense a foundation while Anthony Smith keeps the front dangerous despite veteran losses.

Below that group, the conference gets more fragile. Illinois has a transfer-heavy OL with little shared continuity. Nebraska has enough line talent for a solid floor but several open or replaced high-leverage roles. Maryland, UCLA, Rutgers and Purdue all carry C-range OL projections, which is why their quarterback optimism has to be discounted. Northwestern's offense replaces two NFL-drafted linemen, and Wisconsin's best five is both rebuilt and health-sensitive.

The November rule: portal/resource depth matters more as the season progresses. The Big Ten has enough elite defensive fronts and enough cross-country travel that a merely competent starting five can look fine in September and become a liability once injuries and repeated physical games accumulate.

10. Schedule & Swing Games

Relatively more manageable paths

This is relative. No Big Ten contender has a schedule that should be called easy.

- **Penn State - SP+ SOS No. 59:** The conference's clearest schedule beneficiary. The Nittany Lions avoid Ohio State, Oregon and Indiana while getting USC at home.
- **Oregon - No. 21:** Still hard, but the Ducks get Michigan and Washington at Autzen and have a bye immediately after the USC trip.
- **Indiana - No. 32:** The first four games are at home, and the late bye provides a reset before USC. The Ohio State-Michigan sequence remains the defining stress point.
- **Iowa - No. 33:** The schedule includes Ohio State and Michigan but avoids Oregon, Indiana and USC, giving the defense enough manageable weeks to preserve an eight-win path.
- **Minnesota - No. 31:** A bowl-level team gets enough middle-tier games to reach six wins if the offense improves, even though the overall schedule is still rated hard.

Most demanding paths

- **Ohio State - SP+ SOS No. 3:** Texas in nonconference play plus Indiana, USC, Oregon, Nebraska and Michigan makes even the country's best roster vulnerable to a two-loss regular season.
- **Michigan - No. 5:** Oklahoma, Penn State, Indiana, Oregon and Ohio State give a new staff almost no room for prolonged adjustment.
- **Northwestern - No. 6:** A bowl-bubble roster has to survive one of the nation's hardest slates while breaking in a new QB and rebuilt OL.
- **Nebraska - No. 10:** The back half becomes dramatically more demanding, which can make early progress look like late regression.
- **USC - No. 11:** Oregon, Washington, Penn State, Ohio State and Indiana create five games against teams with top-20 or better underlying profiles.

Games most likely to shape the race

- 1 **Sept. 26 - Oregon at USC** - Oregon's first Big Ten game immediately tests the rebuilt OL against the best offense outside the title tier.
- 2 **Oct. 10 - USC at Penn State** - the conference's best schedule-path team gets a direct home test against a stronger neutral-field roster.
- 3 **Oct. 17 - Ohio State at Indiana** - a rematch of the 2025 Big Ten Championship Game and the first direct collision inside the three-team title tier.
- 4 **Oct. 17 - Penn State at Michigan** - a major sorting game between favorable-path Penn State and better-than-record Michigan.
- 5 **Oct. 24 - Indiana at Michigan** - the second week of Indiana's defining Ohio State-Michigan sequence.
- 6 **Oct. 31 - Ohio State at USC** - a top-three schedule team visits the conference's best non-title-tier offense.
- 7 **Nov. 7 - Oregon at Ohio State** - the cleanest preseason matchup between the Big Ten's top two underlying teams.
- 8 **Nov. 14 - Michigan at Oregon** - Michigan's roster quality gets another elite stress test in Eugene during Oregon's November gauntlet.

- 9 **Nov. 28 - Michigan at Ohio State** - rivalry stakes meet possible conference-championship and CFP sorting pressure on the final weekend.

The sequencing is as important as the raw SOS numbers. **Ohio State** gets a bye immediately before USC-Oregon. **Indiana** plays Ohio State and Michigan back-to-back, then later gets a bye before USC. **Oregon** has its most punishing stretch entirely in November. **Washington** closes Nebraska-Penn State-Michigan State-Indiana-Oregon. **Nebraska** can build an encouraging early record before the schedule turns into a weekly test of whether the improvement is real.

11. Teams to Watch

Penn State - how much can familiarity accelerate a transition?

Matt Campbell is not installing a normal Year 1 rebuild. Rocco Becht arrives with direct system familiarity, and several imported pieces understand the ecosystem. That can raise the floor faster than a typical staff change. The question is whether the transfer-heavy lines and defense are actually top-20 quality or simply well organized enough to capitalize on the schedule.

Washington - Demond Williams Jr. as the ceiling raiser

Washington is already a +16.0 team before pricing in a full QB leap. Williams has enough experience and dual-threat ability to push the offense beyond its median projection, which matters because the roster is replacing several premium professionals. If the OL is merely stable, Washington can be the conference's most dangerous second-tier team in November.

Iowa - can the identity survive the QB/OL reset?

The Hawkeyes' 8-4 baseline assumes the program floor survives a major offensive transition. That is reasonable because the defense remains the structural center of the team. It is not guaranteed because the quarterback competition is unresolved and three drafted OL starters are gone. If the offense is functional rather than merely survivable, Iowa can finish above fifth.

Illinois - the stable-core test

Illinois has a veteran quarterback in Katin Houser and enough leadership continuity to remain a top-30 team, but the roster around that core is changing heavily on both sides. The 2026 question is whether a few stable high-leverage pieces can preserve the program floor when the supporting cast is much less familiar than the 2025 version.

UCLA - new-coach upside versus Big Ten physics

UCLA is a useful test of the difference between a good coaching hire and an immediately good team. Bob Chesney and Nico Iamaleava give the Bruins a clear plan, but the line and defense are transfer-heavy and the 2025 efficiency baseline was poor. If the imported roster holds up physically, the Bruins can reach the top half. If not, Year 1 improvement may be more visible on film than in the standings.

Nebraska - do not overreact to September

Nebraska can start well and still finish near 6-6 because the schedule gets much harder. That makes the Cornhuskers one of the league's easiest teams to misread early. The useful evaluation is whether Colandrea, the new RB rotation and Aurich's defense produce sustainable efficiency before Indiana-Oregon-Washington-Illinois-Ohio State turn the schedule into a stress test.

12. Team Primer Directory

For the full roster, coaching, unit-grade, player and schedule breakdowns, open the individual team primers:

Team	Full 2026 team primer
Ohio State	Ohio State 2026 Preseason Primer
Oregon	Oregon 2026 Preseason Primer
Indiana	Indiana 2026 Preseason Primer
USC	USC 2026 Preseason Primer
Michigan	Michigan 2026 Preseason Primer
Penn State	Penn State 2026 Preseason Primer
Washington	Washington 2026 Preseason Primer
Iowa	Iowa 2026 Preseason Primer
Illinois	Illinois 2026 Preseason Primer
Nebraska	Nebraska 2026 Preseason Primer
Minnesota	Minnesota 2026 Preseason Primer
UCLA	UCLA 2026 Preseason Primer
Maryland	Maryland 2026 Preseason Primer
Northwestern	Northwestern 2026 Preseason Primer
Wisconsin	Wisconsin 2026 Preseason Primer
Rutgers	Rutgers 2026 Preseason Primer
Michigan State	Michigan State 2026 Preseason Primer
Purdue	Purdue 2026 Preseason Primer

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